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“The market has been growing at double the rate it was growing five years ago and is projected to keep growing at a medium to high rate—Shyam Pandey, senior manager-sales & operations, Kits'n'Spares

cational kits is just what the budding engineers need to solve the real-world problems. Now that colleges have started realising the potential of hands-on training, educational and hobby kits providers see busy years ahead. The market has been growing at double the rate it was growing five years ago and is projected to keep growing at a medium to high rate,” says Shyam Pandey, senior manager-sales & operations, Kits'n'Spares.

“There are over 5000 engineering colleges in India and, on an average, there are 1000 students in each college (taking into account all branches and all years). This means there are a total of five million students. Sixty per cent of them, i.e., three million, are from mechanical, electrical and computer science streams. If we take 10 per cent (which is a very modest number) of that and assume that, on an average, they spend Rs 1000 a year on robotic kits, then the market is worth Rs 300 million,” informs Adwait Deshpande, R&D head, Robotics, Thinklabs.

“However, many of the players in this industry are primarily importers and distributors of educational and hobby products. The products are imported without paying customs duty and other taxes and sold without proper paper work. There is no quality assurance,” adds Pandey.

Main consumers

Engineering colleges, vocational training centres, R&D organisations and defence establishments are the main consumers. Also, there is some demand from hobbyists.

“Of course, technical training institutes are the largest contributor to the growth of the educational kits industry,” says Rajesh Suresh Joshi, manager-business development,



Component trainer from Edkits

Dynalog (India).

“Educational institutions want the latest technology in compact form at economical rates,” adds V. Ravindranathan, chief executive, Minmax Electronics.

Generally, they make two types of purchases:

1. Purchase of lab equipment as per the syllabus of the university. Standard equipment like oscilloscope and meters come under this category.

2. Purchase of advanced and latest products so that the students and staff become familiar with new technologies.

What's in demand

“Embedded kits, kits using solar technology and robotic kits are in demand,” says Manilal Gala, proprietor, Vegakit India. There is a large demand for AVR and PIC microcontroller development boards from engineering colleges in particular.

“Technology has been changing from solidstate devices to VVLSI chips, and from experiments on-board to